

SECONDS SALE

Strapped for cash but still yearning for that second PC? Here's an idea: how about a secondhand computer for around Rs 12,000!

decent condition? What happens if it breaks down? Will you get a warranty? Well, let's take a look.

Why buy a secondhand PC?

The first and most obvious consideration, of course, is cost. The second is what you're going to use the computer for.

Most people buy way more computing power than they actually need or will be utilising. If you intend to delve into high-end graphics and design, run software such as Photoshop or play games, you need a powerful computer. But if you're going to use it for surfing the Web, chat, or for simple word processing then a P4 running at 1.5 GHz with 128 MB RAM and a 40 GB hard disk is unnecessarily extravagant. A Pentium II or a Pentium III with lower RAM and storage would do just fine. For simple data entry you can get by with a 486 for as little as Rs 5,000. (See box 'Price Watch' for approximate prices).

The bottom line is, if you don't need a cutting edge computer, the secondhand market can provide you with some great deals.

Where can I buy a secondhand PC?

There are all kinds of used PCs in the market, from 486s to fairly decent Pentium III machines. They come from home users who trade in their computers for new systems to keep up with the rapid advancements in computing. Many companies also sell off entire office systems, including PCs, peripherals and office automation systems—which could be anywhere from 50 to 500 PCs at one go—to a vendor and buy a similar number of new PCs. The vendors refurbish these machines and sell them in the open market, usually small towns.

Ideally, sourcing it from friends, neighbours or a person you know is the best option. This way you have some idea about the condition the computer was kept in. Alternatively, you could ask your friendly neighbourhood dealer to keep a lookout for people selling off their old PCs.

Since it isn't everyday that you'll have people you know selling off computers, try classified advertisements in your local newspaper where you'll find a number of vendors advertising the sale of used or refurbished PCs.

Manoj Shah, of Used Computer Bazaar, a division of Hemjay Technology and Marketing Services, Mumbai, has an entire section just for refurbished PCs, ranging from 486s to Pentium-IIIs to secondhand notebooks and peripherals. He sells over 75-100 secondhand machines a month to customers from Maharashtra, Gujarat and Rajasthan.

Auctions at sites such as Baazee.com and Indiatimes.com are also a great source

IMAGING: Solomon Lewis

Buying a new PC is a major investment. Even though technology has become cheaper, a new PC can set you back by anything upward of Rs 25,000. And this is just for a PC with the bare minimum features.

But now, there's a way out for those of you that don't have enough money to spring for a new PC. Used or secondhand computers available for significantly less could serve you just as well. But a few important queries need to be answered first: can you get a used computer in a

caution Test Drive before you Buy

If your vendor gives you a testing warranty then it is all the more imperative that you know what to watch out for while giving the machine a 'test drive'.

- Make sure that the machine 'POSTs' (Power Supply On Self Test) at the first attempt.
- Check the hard disk drive for bad sectors. Sometimes a freshly formatted drive will not reflect bad sectors if you run an ordinary scandisk. A low level surface scan is more likely to reveal problems.
- Play a CD or copy files to check if the CD-ROM drive is working fine.